

TOP OF THE TIFFIN



SOUTH INDIAN BREAKFAST MTR, BANGALORE



SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN

If there is a long line of people waiting outside a building at 7 a.m., it has to be the Mavalli Tiffin Room (MTR). Hospitality and welcome smiles be damned, a scowl and a quick push is what awaits you when you finally manage to enter. For MTR is more of an institution than a place to just have your breakfast. You can't help but wax eloquent over the crisp masala dosas, the fluffy idlis that come with coconut and spicy red chutney, and the south Indian filter coffee brought in special silver cups. The rava idli is notorious for vanishing from the kitchen even before 9 a.m. Started in 1924, by Harishchandra Maiyya, MTR is a family-run business that prides itself on its hygiene and the open kitchen that anyone can walk into. But the word 'decor' is

MTR IS MORE OF AN INSTITUTION THAN A PLACE TO HAVE YOUR BREAKFAST.

alien to the powers that be, with an emphasis on functionality. And, yet, every morning it's swarming with politicians, ministers, film stars and the like. Actor Shashi Kapoor is known to head straight to MTR from the airport when he comes to Bangalore. A full breakfast with five-six items, juice or coffee works out to Rs 150 per head. Steep by south Indian standards—but then, it's not MTR for nothing.

by Nirmala Ravindran